

The constant theme that these applets convey is that it is possible to mimic the real-life environment in a laboratory, with computer animation. Interactive Java applets allow a student to play around with variables more conveniently and quickly than would be possible in a laboratory. This enhances the comprehension of the subject among students. From a teacher's point of view, the preclusion of the need to set up all apparatus before an experiment, and spend resources to maintain these apparatus and worry about damages caused by curious students, is a strong reason to invest in animations as a replacement for lab experiments. In the same vein, it needs to be pointed out that these animations are best used as repetitive learning tools. Even though the conceptual knowledge can be gained through an applet, the physical experience of handling instruments is important, and cannot be replicated on a computer.

1.8. Discussion Forums And Newsgroups

Discussion boards / bulletin boards are places where like-minded people come to share their thoughts, seek assistance, and offer advice on a subject. These are places where students who require guidance on any topic related to the subject should head to. Due to the fact that the other members of the groups also share a passion for the subject, it is possible to get a sympathetic ear for your problems, besides knowledgeable advice. For someone who considers himself an expert on the subject, a forum is a great place to make a mark for oneself by solving problems faced by others. Besides helping others, a forum is also the place to share knowledge, and keep abreast of new developments across the world.

1.8.1 Physics Forums

(<http://physicsforums.com>)

This seems by far the most active of forums dedicated to the subject. Besides physics, the site also caters to a few other related subjects like maths, astronomy and engineering. The forum is well organised into sections and topics. The various sections include